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Butch Miles Part II
(The Covid Interview, and more)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period.

Butch was interviewed via Zoom on October 9, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have a re-visit with drummer Butch Miles. Thanks for joining me today.

BM: I'm very happy to be here, Monk, thank you for asking me.

MR: So it was 25 years and 8 months since our last interview.

BM: Wow.

MR: I kept doing the math. It was at the Paradise Valley Jazz Party.

BM: Yeah. I remember that was Don and Sue Miller's Jazz party in Paradise Valley, yeah.

MR: And I recall you came for your interview right after walking off an upbeat set of music and you described yourself as a charter member of the Elvin Jones school of perspiration.

BM: That's very true. That was my introductory line because I used to — shall we say for the genteel crowd, I would perspire quite a bit. I don't seem to do that that much anymore because I don't seem to have much occasion to play that hard anymore.

MR: Okay. Well I was going to ask you about that, but first I wanted to — there's been this odd thing on my mind sort of since that interview. You said early on when you were learning the drums and the music that was being played on the radio was, you know, late 50s, early 60s rock & roll. And you didn't care for it that much because it boom-whack-whack-boom-boom. So just to clear it up for me, was that boom-whack-whack-boom-boom? Or boom-whack-whack-boom-BOOM?

BM: Actually you're leaving out a whack. It was whack-whack-boom-boom-whack.

MR: Okay.

BM: Or, if you really felt adventurous, it was boom-whack-boom-boom-whack-whack. Or boom-whack-whack-boom-whack-boom-whack, which, to his credit, Charlie Watts still plays, to this day.

MR: You can't beat a classic.

BM: No, no. I mean there are sometimes when just the oldies and the goodies are the only thing that will really fit the bill you know. So you can't go wrong sometimes with just going boom-whack-boom-boom-whack. That's it.

MR: Be sure to tell your students that, will ya?

BM: I usually do but they forget it. They're off on more adventurous trips than I am.

MR: Yes. How are you making out during this pandemic and in the part of the country you're in. Do you stay mostly in or do you get out?

BM: No, we get out very rarely, because we're in Texas. I live, my wife and I live just outside of Austin, Texas, and I teach down the road about from my house to my office is about 18 miles. And I teach down in San Marcos, Texas at Texas State University. It's an excellent school. They've got a fine jazz program down there, a wonderful school of music. I just did — it's been a dream, you know, for me, for about the last 12, 13 years I've been down there. But with the pandemic we don't go out too much. As a matter of fact we just drove down to one of our favorite Mexican cantinas and ordered to go for brunch and brought it back here and ate. And I do some teaching on campus face to face, but I also have a few Zoom meetings that I teach online. And Monk, I've got to tell you, it's no secret, I really hate it. I just can't lean over, I can't show someone the proper hand technique or the certain accent that should be performed right at that moment. There's just something lost in the spontaneity of, you know, going online. That's not to say that online doesn't have its particular pros, it's a lot of cons for me because I'm not used to it. It's something I'm just not used to.

MR: Yeah, and I second that. The Zoom, you know I teach saxophone lessons via Zoom and for one thing Zoom doesn't seem to like saxophones.

BM: Well Zoom sure doesn't like drumsets I'll tell you that.

MR: Like you know you start playing and than you hear silence and then it starts to like sort of learn how to handle it. But it's not a great way to do things. I guess it's the best we have at this moment and we hope it will pass. I had a not a really formed question, but, with wind instruments and improvising, teaching jazz, the amount of material and research and so forth, jazz pedagogy has been leaps and bounds for years and years. I wonder if in the teaching of the drumset has been the same way. Has it changed a lot? Like the method books or what you're expected to teach and what the students are expecting to learn?

BM: It is changing quite a bit. It's in the process right now, Monk, of changing a lot. When I first started learning all about drums and drumsets, there were just a couple of books that were my method of manuals that may teacher had supplied me and was giving me lessons out of. They didn't go very far. They weren't really adaptable to the drumset. But this is because I started taking lessons back in the late 50s, you know around 1957, '58, and there wasn't a whole lot of material. Things have changed and improved so much, you got away from a lot of the drum authors who were writing some pretty good "How To" books, but really couldn't demonstrate very much, to the drummers who can play all over the place and imparting that knowledge and their own manuals, you've got the people

that, bless his heart, the great Jim Chapin. Or you have all other kinds of folks, one of the graduates from North Texas, one of the funkiest drummers in the world, Mr. Rick Latham, wrote an entire, a number of manuals about funk drumming. You've got brush work, Clayton Cameron, the great Clayton Cameron on brushes. You've got Ed Thigpen on brushes. You've got all sorts of wonderful manuals and drum methods now that are workable and usable, and they're written by people who actually can play that. But it's going into a different fashion now. There's a whole other area of jazz that's on the rise, along with the jazz/funk and the fusion and stuff for drummers anyway, it's called linear drumming. And it's where you have four-way coordination but not everything necessarily hits at the same time. You may have your hands and your feet all play but they don't ever hit in conjunction with each other. It's brilliant. It's difficult. And it seems to be the coming thing. It's just that with this pandemic I don't know where we're going to play it.

MR: Right. Now I'm going to take a pause for a moment because my connection here needs to go from — I think I need to plug in my —

Okay we're back. So the student that comes in and plays — the first thing they show you is the recreation of a Steve Smith drum solo or a Butch Miles drum solo, and you say, "Very impressive. And now —"

BM: Well the way the I like to try to teach my students with using some of these various methods is that I'll teach them the methods themselves, the techniques that are in there. Because I'm a big believer in muscle memory, especially with drummers. If you play something and practice something over and over and over and over and over, you know exactly what I mean, sooner or later, believe it or not folks, the muscles will start to retain the memory of the motion that you're making. And then you stop increasing the width of the thoughts that goes into the playing. You decrease the width of the thought to the beginning of the thought and the muscles react to the thought. It's the old physics thing, action-reaction that Duke Ellington was a big fan of. So I just took a page out of his book. You get the muscles trained to the nth degree and you begin to think of something, the muscles will respond and then you let them lead you down whatever musical storied path that you want them to lead. And as long as you've got the technique to back it up you can play anything that you even begin to think of. I know it sounds like some kind of Zen B.S. but it's not really. I've been my happiest when I was playing and enjoying what I was playing rather than thinking of what I was going to play next.

MR: That begs the question, the relationship between ideas, creative ideas and technique, do you have to have the technique first so that you can then pull off these ideas that you get?

BM: Well that's a very good question and I would have to answer not necessarily. No. I've heard a number of fine players with sensational technique and they do not have any creativity to speak of. So all they're doing is playing everything that they've heard before

or heard somebody else do, and they play it brilliantly. I mean I know some guys who are friends of mine that can outplay me seven days from Sunday, but they can't out-think me. So the creativity is something else that is very personal and comes from you inside. It also comes from listening, gathering information, hearing other musicians, wondering how they're doing that, wondering what would happen if you did that, wondering what would happen if you did that but you did it this way, and trying to see how it would sound if you did it this way instead of that way. There's the creative section coming to spark.

MR: I see.

BM: But in many instances a lot of good technique is helpful. I'm not going to beat around the bush. In the musicians' terms for the lay people, you've just got to have the chops, baby."

MR: Yeah. I'm going to write that one down, "you've got to have the chops, baby."

BM: I get a finder's fee on that one.

MR: Yeah. I'm going to make an assumption that there were a few people along the way who were non-drummers but imparted some "how to play the drums wisdom" to you. Is that a fair statement?

BM: Oh yes.

MR: And who might they have been?

BM: Well my first teacher was a gentleman back in Charleston, West Virginia by the name of Frank Thompson. I sing Frank's praises everywhere I have ever been, because Frank didn't teach me a whole lot of the technique. He wasn't saying okay now here you're going to be going into a double paradiddle, and here are the specific drums that you hit within the specific timeframe of this paradiddle in 4/4. However, if you change it to 3/4 here's your problem. We never got into that. We never did that. I fumbled around on most of that all by myself and made myself miserable a lot of the times. Frank somehow always showed me what would work in the simplest fashion and then it was up to me to see if I can embellish it. The very first thing he ever taught me when I sat down behind a drumset was always let the band know where one is, one being the downbeat. If you get all cute and you're playing above your head and the band's head, they're going to get lost and a musical train wreck on stage is not a pretty sight. Trust me. There's some stories I don't want to tell here so.

MR: Oh come on, you can tell us.

BM: Well there was the time I sat in with a band and they said, "We're going to play 'Night in Tunisia.'" And I said, "Okay, great" not knowing about the four bar break after the insert before each solo starts. I had only been taught about two bar breaks. So we get to the end of it and I take a two bar break and come in on measure three big as life, while the soloist

is still setting up his entrance. And to this day I have never forgotten it. I made a big mistake and I learned from it. Ah, there's a secret.

MR: Did Basie ever like raise his eyebrows and give you a look that you interpreted as, I'm not going to do that again.

BM: No he didn't, and that's a good question too. Basie had a series of signals that he would give to me. Raising the eyebrows was one. Raising the eyebrows meant to increase the volume or to get ready for the explosion. That's how — that's how physical he would become on the bandstand. You know, we're not talking Stan Kenton and waving the arms from wall to wall. Basie had a minimum of motion to give me direction. Sometimes when we were playing he would tilt his head. That's where he'd want the beat, on two and four. He'd want me to accent that and make it stronger. Sometimes he would raise his shoulders when we would come in on an explosion like at the beginning of "All of Me." And that was the signal to let it rip. There were a few things like that.

MR: Okay.

BM: But he never, ever gave me any sort of information or looks or direction that said he was unhappy with what I was doing or don't do that. That leads to a story, I have got to tell you this story, you've drawn me into it.

MR: Please.

BM: Freddie Green, the great Freddie Green, you know, the great guitarist, Mr. Time we called him, was on the band all his life practically. And I was new on the band. I'd been on the band a few months. And I was playing, I was learning the charts and things were going pretty good. And one night, which I have never ever forgotten, one night we're playing and Freddie is sitting off just sort of a little bit off to my right. And suddenly he stops playing. He uncrosses his legs, puts his guitar down, turns around and looks at me, shakes his head, turns back around, re-crosses his legs, picks up his guitar and starts playing. To this day I have no idea what that was about. Ever. That was his version of "the ray." Something was going on and Freddie was just making a statement.

MR: Wow. Man that's like, I mean you could go to bed for the rest of your life and go what was that, Freddie?

BM: What did I do? But I do have to admit in all honesty, and I'm not going to name names, but I've talked with some of the other wonderful drummers that were in the band and they were all subject to Freddie Green turning and looking at them at one point or another. And maybe with the exception of Harold Jones, I don't know, Harold never let anything get him down, with the exception of Jonesie I think all of us are still worried about whatever the hell it was the Freddie meant, all this time, all these years, what did he mean, what was I doing, oh my God. But I don't know what it meant, Monk, I have no idea. But it sure messed my mind up for a long time.

MR: Well he was like a, as you say, a constant. So did you find that he was — I'm not sure how to say this, who was the metronome in the band?

BM: Well that was divided between Freddie and Basie. And that leads to another story. Welcome to story time with Uncle Butch, children. Freddie was so strong in that band, no microphone. He wasn't amplified in any way, but he was so strong. You could always hear him and always feel him when he was playing. Case in point. On any recording of "L'il Darlin'" primarily basically, especially with me, Basie would play his intro and then sets up the tempo with [scats] and Freddie comes in with that [scats], those five notes and the band comes in [scats]. Every single time, no matter what Basie played, Freddie set it up in a different tempo. And every single time the band went with Freddie Green. Now that's the story — I'm going to come to the real story. The first year I was on the band we took a break over Christmas. In 1975, the Christmas of '75. Came back to work after New Year's, in 1976. (And is he that old? Yes I am.) And I noticed for like a couple of days Freddie Green was nowhere to be found. You didn't see him. He wasn't on the job. So I went to ask Basie, I said, "Chief, where's Green?" And Count Basie said, "Oh he's down in Florida playing some golf. He'll be back in a couple of days." And I thought about it for about two seconds and then I heard Basie say, very quietly, "Maybe now we'll play some of my tempos."

MR: Thank you for that.

BM: True story, true story.

MR: That's great.

BM: It was Freddie Green.

MR: I was kind of wondering about that, like night after night the band chooses Freddie. You know you said in our first interview that when you joined Basie you were young and foolish and scared to death. So I'm wondering if there were other times in your career, before or after Basie, that you found yourself in the situation that you were scared to death?

BM: Pretty much constantly. Whenever I've been in contact with great musicians, magnificent giants, I've always, you know, secretly prayed that I wasn't going to make a fool of myself. If nothing else at least I was going to keep the tempo, which is not an easy thing to do sometimes, especially if you're playing long charts, you know, things that go on for seven, eight, nine, ten minutes. But I have been scared out of my gourd many-a-time.

MR: What about like playing behind Sinatra or Benny Goodman? Would those stand out as times like that?

BM: Well I didn't play per se behind Frank. We did work with Frank Sinatra on a number of occasions. Frank had his own drummer, Irv Cottler, the great Irv Cottler, and I was able to hang out with Irv a little bit, and actually met Sinatra. We had a little chat one night

backstage which was just delightful. So I was in the area. I could see what was happening. And that was great. It was scary enough being around their — on Broadway, it was Count Basie, Frank Sinatra, and Ella Fitzgerald. And then we went out on a little tour in a couple of cities, same group. Then we went over to the Palladium and we did a couple of weeks at the Palladium in London with Frank Sinatra, Sarah Vaughan and Count Basie. And then we did one which actually had me scared all up and down, we did a Royal Command Performance while we were there at the Palladium, where we only played like one or maybe two tunes, but the entire royal family was in attendance. I didn't meet anybody, you know, I wasn't one of the guys chosen to go, you know say, "How do you do, your majesty" or any of that other kind of thing. But still you're told where to look and where not to look and of course you look where you're not supposed to look because you can't help yourself. And you look up there. And I think John Lennon was right. He said, "All you regular folks just applaud, royalty can just shake their jewelry." And you just see power, jewelry and tradition and heritage. You can't even see anybody's face but you know they're there. And you're sweating buckets, I mean it's the royal family. Oh. So I was a nervous wreck. Now Benny Goodman, I did play with Benny. I did one gig with Benny and I knew him off and on for the rest of his life. But we never worked together again. I was definitely on pins and needles because I knew of Benny's reputation. And it didn't turn out that way at all. He and I had some fun. I was told, "Play only brushes." Benny didn't like sticks. Well by the second number that night Benny was looking at me and saying, "Sticks, Butch, sticks." So it helped an awful lot, Monk, that my very first hero of all time was Gene Krupa. So I knew where Benny was going on some of those old, old, old, old, old tunes, and I'd go there. So we got along musically wonderfully. And as I said, many years later we had a small chat on the phone. Outside that I never worked for him again.

MR: Wow.

BM: But scared? Yes. Yes. But we had a wonderful time musically though, we had great fun. We actually traded some fours. I didn't think that was going to happen.

MR: Okay. Do you feel your playing has changed over the years either out of necessity or out of choice?

BM: Yes, yes and yes. It has changed over the years. And some of it has been out of necessity because I had worked for the first four and a half years where I — for wont of a better phrase — made my bones, I was working with the Basie band. And that's where I got my reputation. Then the next thing I turned around, as you remember, and I joined up with Dave Brubeck's quartet. (How could he do that?) Well it was easy for me because I was raised on both Basie and Brubeck. Then later I started playing with other groups, more trad oriented, more, definitely solid in the 1940s swing oriented, and a few other bands

that were of a different type of, oh I don't know what the word would be, a connotation for a musical genre or a style, and I found that I just couldn't stay in one particular crevice, a musical crevice as it were. I couldn't apply what I've always been playing to (A) when the band was playing let's say (B) I had to think of something else to play. So I would have to switch and it got me to thinking and got me to changing my style because I had to. And then later on I found that there was so much enjoyment in playing so many different ways and so many different things that it was by my choice. I started experimenting and playing different styles and different rhythms and different beats. I still had my old cliches and they're still there, you can't get rid of them. But I was more adventurous. I didn't have to stay so stuck in any one particular rut anymore. I could go all kinds of different ways. And so I did that by choice. So my playing right now is quite different, not totally different, but it's quite different from what you might hear in 1975, 1977.

MR: Is it possible to be specific about one part of your playing that is different?

BM: I don't state the beat so hard anymore. I don't pound at you. I've learned to get up off that bass drum and use that as a musical voice more often but I still use it as the bottom line in connection with a good walking bass player, not so much to beat somebody up with but just to give a little bit more support to. And use my feet, both feet, as other voices so that I try to think of now, I try to think in more musical terms, percussive terms. I think I got slaughtered on that thing when I was working with Gerry Mulligan and a quartet back in the 80s, and I did a number of gigs with him and the big band, and his big band, some of it, is on YouTube, some very fine TV shows came out of oh I don't know where it's — Italy I think, and we did a number of things with the quartet and a number of things with the big band and I found I had to change my playing style to work with Gerry, and I enjoyed it very much. So I began to re-educate myself, I didn't have to drive so hard all the time. There was something nice to be said for subtlety.

MR: Was that a group without a chordal instrument?

BM: No, no. The ones that I played in with Gerry always had a piano. Harold Danko was on the band for a long time, Bill Mays, the wonderful Bill Mays was there. It was always basically Gerry, piano, bass and drums.

MR: Yeah. I don't know if you've been asked the typical "if you could pick ten recordings because you're stuck on a desert island" question — but, if I was to ask that, I mean you don't have to go through it but would there be any recordings included that you play on?

BM: Oh, good one.

MR: Because I have a candidate by the way.

BM: I would have to say that if I did include one of mine, which, now that you bring it up, offhand I wouldn't, but if I did out of all the albums, I've done over a hundred, a hundred

and some albums with everybody. I mean I recorded with Basie, recorded with Mulligan, recorded with Alberta Hunter. Here's a name for you, Dolly Dawn, there's one, remember that one. And a lot of different people. There'd be a Basie recording which is called "Live in Japan." And we recorded that one, not the last one that was recorded about 2007 I think or 2006, but way before when it was recorded back in 1978. The band was smoking hot and I just had all of my you-know-what together. And we were a unit. It was glorious and it was beautiful, and that would be the one. Other than that it's a lot of stuff that sometimes I can listen to but barely.

MR: Well.

BM: Oh, Dick Hyman, yeah.

MR: Dick Hyman and —

BM: And Milt Hinton.

MR: Milt Hinton, what a team, Urbie Green, Bucky Pizzarelli, Joe Temperley, Frank Wess, Joe Wilder, and Dick Hyman charts. And actually this one I would have on my desert island list.

BM: That's a good one. I have to tell you I forgot about that really. But that is a very good album specifically because of the giants that are all on there that I'm just trying to keep time for, and not get in their way. They play so beautifully, they play so musically, they play so, just magnificent.

MR: Yes. And the CD, the recording starts with just a quartet, no horns, and I believe it's off-the-cuff, and Dick Hyman sets up the tempo much like Basie would. And you come in. And all you're playing is the hi-hat and the stand. I mean you probably don't remember it but it made such an impression on me because it's just such like a tick-tick-a-tick-tick. And it's so hip, and you've got all this room to go into and I just think it's like a drum lesson right there.

BM: Well thank you very much. Thank you. I remember now, Dick Hyman was so brilliant, he said, "Listen fellas," I remember this strangely enough, I don't know why but I do. He looked at us before we started recording and said, "Listen fellas, I want to start off, we're going to make something up. It's going to be the lead-off on the album and we'll make this up." He said, "Now Butch, you and Milt have worked with Count Basie before." "Yeah." He said, "Give me a Basie style tempo and Bucky, you do your Freddie Green thing" so the rhythm section was all ready to go, and so we jumped in and we said, "Okay here's what we're going to do" and then Dick started to jam over the top of that and then the rest of it you know exactly what happened. Dick Hyman is such a gentleman that when the album was released he sent all of us a note and he said — me and Milt and Bucky, he said, "Because you set it up and you guys were the ones who came up with the Basie ideas, I'm giving you co-writing rights on this one so that you'll also get a little bit

of extra change for all the albums that are sold," because we were listed as co-writers. He's a gentleman.

MR: I can confirm that, I'm looking at it right now, "From the Age of Swing, Hyman, Hinton, Pizzarelli and Miles. That's awesome.

BM: For ideas, and because the maestro, Maestro Hyman, had suggested that we come up with some ideas for rhythm in a Basie style.

MR: Yeah. Well you sure did.

BM: Thank you.

MR: I've been waiting to ask you about that record because I know when you record so many things sometimes you can't really remember them. It's like a day at work, right?

BM: Renaissance Records?

MR: Yes. Reference Recording.

BM: Oh Reference Recordings.

MR: They recorded at SUNY Purchase.

BM: Yes sir, up in White Plains.

MR: Yes.

BM: And I think they had some new microphones, some omni-directional microphones I think, that they set up on the stage instead of having mics on each and every instrument you know, and overhanging the drums and on the bass and the snare and stuff. They had one or two or three microphones set up to catch the live effects of the auditorium, the theater that we were playing in. So the sound is different.

MR: Yes, they got it. So I've had a couple of circumstances recently where I'll make a reference to a student, let's say I might say something like, "You know that Weather Report 'Birdland' wonderful recording —" and they'll look at me like with this blank thing. And I'll go oh no, don't tell me. And I could understand it if it was, you know, a Lester Young recording. But I'm wondering if this has happened to you.

BM: Yes. The older I get, the more I teach, the younger the students and the more blank stares I get sometimes when I do exactly what you just did. I suggest a recording, a specific recording from 20, 30, 40, 50 years ago, and it's sort of like I might as well be talking about Fred Flintstone and his band back in Bedrock, or whatever. They've got no idea. But then, in all fairness Monk, they'll look at me and they'll talk about, "Have you heard the latest from" so-and-so. And I don't have any idea who they're talking about. So they impart knowledge to me and I impart knowledge to them. Hopefully.

MR: Hopefully. Yeah.

BM: But I like doing something like you just said, "Okay let's take Weather Report and 'Birdland' and then let's take Buddy Rich's big band and 'Birdland.'" And you listen to the difference of what Peter Erskine, my old buddy Peter Erskine is doing when he's

371 playing with Weather Report as compared to what Buddy did with his own band. When
372 they get to a certain section of "Birdland" Buddy is wailing away and the walls and
373 peeling paint, everything's on fire all around him and he's just going like a rocket blast.
374 Whereas when they get to the same type of section on Weather Report Peter shifts into a
375 shuffle rhythm. He doesn't continue over that straight ahead eighth notes and straight
376 ahead sixteenth. He goes into a shuffle with a big backbeat and you compare both
377 sections, both bands, both artists are magnificent. It's a different take. And I like to listen
378 to both.
379 MR: Good point. Yeah. I mean let's be honest. Is there anything better than a good shuffle
380 rhythm?
381 BM: Not really. A good shuffle, when it's right in the pocket is, oh man. I can't remember,
382 you just gave me an idea, a thought. I was driving home one day many years ago and I
383 was listening to like a light rock station. And I heard the beginning of what almost
384 sounded like the beginning of "Spirit in the Sky" but that wasn't the recording. But the
385 band in the background went [scats] just that, the bass player and the guitar player. And
386 every once in a while someone would lean in and say, "Mercy" and then [scats]. And I
387 nearly wrecked the car. I nearly drove into a telephone pole. It came in so strong, so
388 clean, no extra little [scats] anything like that, it just went right for the jugular. And I just
389 jumped up and shouted. And I was driving the car. And it laid in that pocket with nothing
390 else but a spectacular straight ahead, kill your mother, shuffle rhythm. Man. And to this
391 day I don't know who that was.
392 MR: Yeah. It's so fascinating. I've been obsessed with the — I don't know if it's the actual
393 original but Wilbert Harrison's version of Kansas City. If you listen to that, it's so perfect
394 and it just drives, and I can't even imagine the recording technology at that time but
395 there's something about it. There's this chunk-a-chunk-a-chunk-a-chunk. You can't even
396 recognize the instrument. But I'm not sure where I'm going with this but boy when things
397 work they just are awesome.
398 BM: The greatest break on drums in rock & roll has been played all kinds of different ways
399 and by all kinds of different people. Most folks remember it from Phil Collins and a
400 couple of the albums he did because he always did double stops on it. He would play
401 something on the drumset, then he would play it again backing himself up so it would
402 sound like three, four, five guys at the same time. But there was a groove by a gentleman
403 by the name of Junior Walker and his band Junior Walker and the All-Stars.
404 MR: Yeah.
405 BM: And I couldn't find anybody until I finally ran into an older gentleman, a great drummer,
406 and we were talking and I said, "Do you know about this break?" And he said, "Yeah,
407 that's Junior Walker and the All-Stars, that's 'Shotgun.'" And the band goes [claps] like

this. And what a difference. The simplicity of that. But it's right in every way what you're saying. It sets up right, it plays right, it leads right and it just does the job. What else do you need?

MR: Indeed. And you know I've experienced that lick because I've played tenor sax in bands that do that song, and of course it goes [scats] but the sax has to come [scats] and you better be ready.

BM: Yes you better.

MR: Wow.

BM: I've never played that tune. I never have. But I would love to one of these days. Maybe. Because I've got that break down.

MR: I've got that break down. Before we started I found a little video of you. It looked like you were in a music store and you were playing the hi-hat. Right? And you were showing some things with the — and I said okay I'm going to have Butch Miles come to Hamilton College and all he has to do is bring his hi-hat.

BM: I'd love to. I'd love to. That's one of the things that I'm — when I teach jazz majors on drumset that's one of the things that I am a definite dog about, that hi-hat. And I'm so proud to say that two years ago I had a young lady who had gone through all percussion and she was a jazz major on drumset. And part of her master thesis and her recital she had taken and written out and performed her own version of Max Roach's "Papa Jo" otherwise subtitled "One for Papa" and/or "Mr. Hi-hat." Nothing but hi-hat, just that, and did a wonderful job. People don't understand, Monk, how tough that little thing is to play and what a huge difference it makes within the drumset itself. It's a whole other voice.

MR: Yeah. What do you tell your, with jazz majors, what do you advise to them as far as post-graduation and making a living?

BM: Swing or I'll kill you. No, no, it's just old jokes, sorry. Old musicians will remember that old joke. It's like Joe Morello told me one time, he said, "A lot of times you can't remember how many bars there are to a tune, but the old musicians can remember how many tunes there are to a bar" and I left my cowbell down on the campus, God-dog it.

MR: I got it. Okay.

BM: Things were a little bit different before March of this year. You could still tour. You could work around the country. You could get gigs. There were some nice gigs. There were studios to be had where you could be on call. Not like the old, old days where you could make a good living being in the studio recording like let's say the Wrecking Crew out in L.A. when they'd get all those huge hits so many years ago out in California. But there's still a lot of work out there. And I say that in the past tense because now you can't go anywhere and you can't play anywhere due to the situation, the medicinal situation and the infections and the pandemic. So I'm not exactly sure what to tell the guys, the

kids, the men and women who come through my classes and take lessons and study with me. I'm not sure what's going to happen. But this is a new age, this is a new time, and this is something that you can be very worried about and at the same time you can really charge ahead full steam because this sounds like this is the dawning of the Age of Aquarius. You've got to come up with something new and something fresh, and some way to make a living and some way to play music in order to just get it done. So creative minds are going to be coming up with some incredibly brilliant things that we never had to think of before. And I think it's because it's necessity. We have to in order to play music and sustain making a living. They are going to come up with some wild things to do and wonderful ways to do it. I just don't know what it is yet. I'm as big a fan of all the guys who are thinking all of this stuff up as anybody else. One thing I've noticed is that some of the great musicians have a working situation where they're not all piled on top of each other, like in a small club. They've got distancing and they wear masks, except when maybe a wind instrument, a saxophone or a trumpet or trombone or something is playing, and you get together for small concerts. An hour concert, an hour and a half concert. And you can donate by way of personal checks or by credit cards or PayPal or some other things. And some people are doing fairly well right now, at least continuing to play and make a little bit of money, but it's going to go a different way and I just don't know where. And I'm going to be very excited to see what the young minds today are going to come up with.

MR: Well that's a good attitude to have because yeah, change is constant, and especially now. There was an article in the last DownBeat, which I just read today, about how do you justify going to a music school now and spending the bucks and so forth when we have this situation. And they had a pretty good answer. They were saying a variation of what you did and people are going to be combining their musicianship with their technology innovations. And I think people have always had to figure out how to find a niche and I suppose that is true more now than ever.

BM: I think so. And I think that's exactly what they're going to have to do. Because I have taken great offense at very nice folks who will say something like, "Boy I can't wait until this is over and things get back to normal." Things are never going to get back to normal. You know? So we have to figure out how we can operate in the new normal. I found that out, I've been living a new normal for over six years now. I had a lung transplant back in 19 — [20] 14. And I had to totally change my lifestyle around so wearing a mask, carrying, even in my office here, carrying hand sanitizer, I'm wearing gloves, I've got Lysol spray, I have Clorox wipes with me all the time. Over six years now, six and a half years. So this isn't all that new to me. But it's not going back to what it was. It never will.

So we have to figure out a way that we can survive and exist and create in the new normal. That's all.

MR: You led me to a question that I was contemplating asking so I will, and it has to do with aggravation or anger. I'll start with the music. Are there things on the bandstand that people might do that would aggravate or possibly anger you?

BM: I can't think of anything musically offhand. If someone does something musically and they mean it, if they're not doing it just to be a (excuse the expression) a smart-ass, or to try to start a fight, but if they're actually playing from the heart I wouldn't get mad at that. What I would get mad at is attitude. If you know that it's bad for the health, it's bad for everybody. You get up on the bandstand, like we always used to do years ago, and the first thing you do is pull out a cigarette and light up. I can't be around cigarettes in no way, shape or form because of that transplant. So that would be a personal slap in my face. Don't do that. Why be so rude from time to time, just don't say anything at all. What's that old tune? If you can't say anything real nice just don't talk at all is my advice. There's a few things that you can comport yourself like a professional on the bandstand. When you get off the bandstand you can go back behind the curtain and kick somebody's butt or get yours kicked too or have a huge argument, as long as it's not on the bandstand. I have worked in the past, and I'm sure you have to, with gentlemen who were great musicians and we just did not see eye to eye. Therefore we did a very good job on the bandstand but we didn't exactly hang out and go to lunch when we weren't working. As long as we could make music, that was very, very important, and I try very hard myself not to badmouth or say something nasty about somebody off the bandstand. It's just that you don't talk about me, I won't talk about you.

MR: Thank you. Do you have the opportunity to try to hip your students to the kind of attitude and demeanor that they need to have to rise to the top of someone's drummer list? Beyond their playing ability.

BM: Every once in a while. I've been very fortunate enough to have some young students who have been extraordinary drummers. And I'd be lying if I said that I had to read them the riot act about how to comport themselves offstage. I haven't, because the young gentlemen and young lady that were so excellent in their playing and when they were on the bandstand or in a concert hall or theater, they always had a wonderful attitude about everything. About the music, about people, about life. I didn't have to say hardly a word ever. Others sometimes who have a bit of a nasty attitude generally are not your best players. Sometimes you'll get somebody who is a great musician and is also a punk. Okay well I just don't want to have too much to do with them and I'd rather listen to the music but I don't want to hang around and let's go out for dinner tomorrow night or let's go to a movie, or like Buddy Rich once said, "Well go to a movie and hold sticks."

Sticks, sticks, sticks. He really did say that. But there's very few people that I've found that have great intelligence and talent that are real crummy people. And I'm lucky that way. I guess I don't have to worry about it. I don't have to think too much about it. There's been a few times when I have sort of guided a musician, one of my students, in a way to handle a situation a little bit better than maybe they did handle it. But I also consider that to be part of the education system. That goes along with drumming, music, and just life in general. You're here, this is university time, welcome to the university. Now you start to think for yourself. Here's some rules, here's some regulations. You can either use these as guidelines or you don't have to. If you don't I'll probably see you some other time because you'll wind up dropping out and getting mad and going somewhere and doing something. But most of the time, the majority of the time, the people, these youngsters are really nice people. And I don't have to say hardly anything.

MR: Well it sounds like you were lucky to, playing with Basie and those folks. You've got life lessons from them. And now, our generation is the one that's, it's our turn to pass them on I guess you could say.

BM: It is. You're absolutely right about that. I learned so much, and I did so much growing up on that bus and those one-nighters, and those stages and gig after gig after gig and meeting people, myriads of different folks from all walks of life who either loved the music or hated the music. It was okay because it was just the experience. I did an awful lot of growing up and that was my experience with the band. And I'm still growing. I find myself now thinking about things I did 30 years ago and I realize I could have handled it better. Because now I've gone through a lot more than what I had before. I wasn't that savvy or even that civilized early on, let's face it, Monk. I was a smart-ass. You know? I'd get off the stage and someone would say something like, "Man that was a great set." And I'd say, "Yeah it was." Why would I do that? Because I was being, you know, the smart ass. Instead of saying thank you very much, which I do now. I appreciate it if someone likes my playing or if someone likes the music, "Thank you very much." I worked very hard to get to do that and I'm glad that you can hear that. I'm glad I can do that for you. But you know that, yeah I can really play, man, you ought to hear me play a shuffle, oh man. Monk Rowe ain't heard nothing yet 'til I play my shuffle. No. You know? I've only heard in my entire life two people that would say something that was outrageous and then back it up completely. And those two people were Buddy Rich and Muhammad Ali. Outside of that you've got to take everybody's pronouncements with a grain of salt.

MR: I took note of, in your first interview you said a wonderful thing about Al Grey, because on the bandstand, especially when you first joined he would like Basie's playing an intro

and Al would lean over and tell you what the tune was. And just that little bit of class obviously stayed with you.

BM: Well thank you. But to this day I'll never forget it from the very first night I was on that band, at the Happy Medium, upstairs at the Happy Medium in Chicago on North Rush Street with the Basie band, January, I think it was the 29th 1975. We did two shows that night. I had not rehearsed, I had not sat in, I hadn't done a thing. It was all pure sweat time. I was scared out of my gourd. And Al Grey would just lean forward and call out the number of the tune. I was fortunate that I knew some of them, but if he hadn't done that I would have been, man I would have been lost in the forest somewhere. It would have been just awful.

MR: Right.

BM: But I never forgot that.

MR: Well this has been a marvelous re-visiting with you and I want to wrap up — I'm going to read something that you said about basically careers in music and you said, "you have to stick in this business because it will kill you, it will just waste you away and then turn around and make your life so marvelous you can't believe you ever thought of a rainy day as anything else except sunshine and beautiful blue skies. Then maybe the next day you're back with clouds and thunderstorms." I'm glad you stuck with it.

BM: Well I'll tell you, what am I now, yeah I'm 76 years old. I'll be 77 next July. I got one decent lung. My body is falling apart. My feet are all busted up and my hands hurt. I take a myriad of medicine. That's hard to say, wow. I wonder if I can copyright that phrase, "a myriad of medicine" every single day. I go to see the doctor a lot. And yet I'm just thrilled to be here. I hear something that excites me, I see something that gives me pleasure, I'm looking over your shoulder and I can finally make it out, you've got "Every Day" up there, you've got a score to "Every Day I Have the Blues." Right?

MR: Yes I do.

BM: I like that. That's very, very nice. Because "Every Day I Have the Blues" good, bad or indifferent. And I'm just very happy to be here because sometimes I get a chance to have an opportunity to enjoy a little chat with an old friend that I haven't seen for a long time like Monk Rowe.

MR: Oh well.

BM: So I'm very happy to be here. Just stick it out. Stick it out.

MR: All right. Well I can't think of a better way to wrap up, Butch, and keep doing it. I'm going to keep doing it. And things may not get back to normal but we'll have something better than right now I'm sure.

BM: It'll be different, that's for sure.

MR: Yes indeed. Okay. Well thanks a lot.

BM: Monk, it's my pleasure. Thank you for the invitation, I appreciate it.

MR: Okay. I'm going to pause our recording here, and we'll see you on the flip side.

BM: Okay. I'm filling everything out and I'm going to send this off to you pretty soon.

MR: Okay.

BM: Send that by email.

MR: All right. Very good.

BM: Thank you so much, Monk, this has been fun.

MR: All right. Me too.